

Hormone A chemical messenger released by the endocrine glands into the bloodstream. It alters the activities of specific tissues.

Immune system

A collection of cells, including macrophages and lymphocytes, that protect the body from disease by destroying germs such as bacteria.

Joint The place where two or more bones meet. Most joints are movable.

Keratin A tough, waterproof protein found in nails, hair, and the upper layer of the skin's epidermis.

Ligament A tough strap that holds bones together at the joints.

Lymph A liquid that is drained from the body's tissues along the vessels of the lymphatic system.

Mammal An animal, such as a rabbit or human, that is warm-blooded, hairy, and feeds its young with milk.

Metabolism All the chemical processes that take place inside every one of the body's cells.

Mitochondria The tiny structures inside cells that release energy from glucose.

Mitosis The division of a body cell into two new, identical offspring cells.

MRI (magnetic resonance imaging)

scan A way of using magnetism, radio waves, and computers to produce images of body tissues and organs.

Mucus A slimy substance released by glands, such as those lining the esophagus that leads from the throat to the stomach.

Muscle fiber One of the cells that makes up a muscle.

Neuron A type of nerve cell that carries signals.

Nucleus The control center of the cell that contains chromosomes.

Nutrient A substance found in food that is needed by the body to function normally.

Organ A body part, such as the heart or kidney, that is made of two or more types of tissue and has specific roles.

Organelle One of the tiny working structures, such as mitochondria, found floating in the cytoplasm of cells.

Oxygen A gas that is used by body cells to release energy from glucose.

Protein A group of substances found in food and inside the body. Proteins build and run the body's cells.

Puberty The period of rapid growth, usually in the early teens, when the reproductive systems start working.

Pulse The rhythmic throbbing of an artery as it expands when blood is pumped through it by the heart. The pulse is the same as the rate the heart beats.

Reflex A rapid, automatic action, such as pulling the hand away from a hot object, that happens without our thinking about it.

Renal Of or relating to the kidney.

Saliva A liquid found in the mouth. It aids digestion by providing the lubrication needed for chewing and swallowing.

SEM (scanning electron microscopy) A way of using a special microscope to produce magnified 3-D images of body tissue.

Sphincter A ring of muscle around an opening that controls the flow of materials through it.

Sweat A watery liquid produced by glands in the skin.

Synapse The junction between two neurons that are separated by a tiny gap.

Synovial joint A free-moving joint, such as the elbow or knee.

System A group of linked organs that work together, such as the organs that make up the digestive system

Tendon A tough cord that links a muscle to a bone.

Tissue A group of cells of the same type—such as muscle cells—that work together to perform a particular function.

Vein A thin-walled blood vessel that returns blood to the heart from the tissues.

Virus A disease-causing particle that invades the body's cells and multiplies inside them, causing infections, such as colds and measles.

X-ray An imaging technique that uses radiation to reveal bones.